

AETHERIA — Game Guideline & Lore Bible

Step 1 deliverable · Source of truth for all subsequent phases

1. Concept Pitch (Elevator)

*A thousand years after the Aether — the world's living energy — shattered into seven Shards, the realm of **Aetheria** drifts apart on floating islands. Heroes of the **Aetherbound** must explore lost continents, reclaim the Shards, outwit rival factions, and master the broken sky before the Void devours what remains.*

Core loop: Explore → Discover → Strategize → Battle → Loot → Level up → Compete (PvE & PvP).

2. Genre & Pillars

- **Genre:** Online turn-based strategy with real-time exploration & live PvP arenas.
- **Design pillars:**
 - 1 **Discovery is reward** — every level hides a secret (lore fragment, rare item, hidden boss).
 - 2 **Mastery, not grinding** — clever party composition & terrain use beat raw stats.
 - 3 **Always saved, always returnable** — auto-save mid-action; resume anywhere.
 - 4 **Social by default** — global ranking, guilds, co-op raids, seasonal tournaments.

3. World & Setting

- **Setting:** High-fantasy archipelago of floating islands suspended over the Voidsea.
- **Era:** Post-Cataclysm "Age of Drift".
- **Tone:** Mystical, hopeful, with grim undertones; visually painterly (think *Octopath Traveler* x *Slay the Spire* x *Genshin Impact* lite).

Six Realms (campaign acts, ~16 levels each)

#	Realm	Theme	Climate / Hazard
1	Verdant Reach	Awakening forests	Bloom storms
2	Ember Wastes	Volcanic ruins	Lava tides, ash gales
3	Frostspire	Ice citadels & wraiths	Blizzards, frozen rivers
4	Tideglass	Sunken cathedrals	Floods, leviathans
5	Skyfall Vault	Cloud fortresses, gravity	Wind shears, anti-gravity
6	Voidmaw	The shattered core	Reality glitches

(Realms 1–6 = 96 levels; 4 bonus "Rift" levels reach 100.)

4. Story Arc (Acts)

- 1 **Awakening** (lvl 1–10) — protagonist Aevra wakes in a ruined shrine; learns of the Aether.

- 2 **Bonds** (lvl 11–25) — recruit Kyo (samurai monk), Lyra (storm mage).
- 3 **Betrayal** (lvl 26–45) — the Council of Thrones is fractured; one Shard is stolen.
- 4 **Schism** (lvl 46–70) — guilds clash; first PvP-tier unlock; rival faction "Obsidian Choir".
- 5 **Descent** (lvl 71–90) — into the Voidmaw; companions can permanently fall.
- 6 **Convergence** (lvl 91–100) — reforge the Aether; multiple endings based on choices.

5. Characters (initial roster of 8 — expandable via gacha-free unlock)

Codename	Class	Role	Signature skill	Unlock
Aevra	Aetherwalker	Hybrid DPS	<i>Shardstep</i> (teleport+strike)	Default
Kyo	Bladepriest	Tank/DPS	<i>Stillpoint</i> (parry chain)	Lv 11 quest
Lyra	Stormcaller	AoE Mage	<i>Tempest Sigil</i>	Lv 18 quest
Brann	Earthwarden	Tank	<i>Bulwark</i>	Lv 25 quest
Mira	Lifebinder	Healer	<i>Verdant Pact</i>	Lv 32 quest
Vex	Shadowblade	Assassin	<i>Voidstep</i>	Lv 40 PvP rank D
Solen	Sunoracle	Support	<i>Daybreak</i>	Lv 55 raid
Null	Voidchild	Wildcard	<i>Entropy</i>	Lv 80 secret

Each character has: 4 active skills, 2 passives, 3 ascension tiers, cosmetic skins.

6. Combat & Strategy System

- **Grid-based** turn combat on 6×8 hex maps with elevation & elemental tiles.
- **Action Points (AP):** 3/turn; movement, attack, skills consume AP; banked AP = 1 only.
- **Elements:** Verdant, Ember, Frost, Tide, Sky, Void. Wheel weak/strong relations.
- **Status:** Burn, Freeze, Poison, Stagger, Aether-Surge (combo trigger).
- **Combo:** Two characters chaining matching elements trigger **Resonance** (+50% dmg, AoE).

7. Exploration Layer

- **Overworld** = node graph per realm; nodes are: Story / Combat / Puzzle / Treasure / Boss / Hidden.
- **Discovery meter** per realm — fill 100% to unlock secret realm boss & cosmetic.
- **Dynamic events** — weather/time-of-day changes spawn rare encounters.
- **Photo Mode** — players capture vistas for social feed (engagement hook).

8. Progression

- **Account level** 1–100 (mirrors campaign).
- **Character ascension** A0–A3 (gear + Aether-cores).

- **Skill tree** branching: each character 12 nodes, respec at any town.
- **Loot tiers**: Common → Rare → Epic → Mythic → Aether-Forged.
- **Crafting** at Forge: combine duplicates + shards to upgrade.

9. Online & Social Features

- **Account system** — email/OAuth (Google, Discord). JWT sessions.
- **Cloud save** — every action snapshotted; offline edits reconciled on reconnect.
- **Live leaderboards** — Global, Regional, Guild, Friends.
- **Ranked PvP** — Bronze→Mythic, seasonal reset.
- **Guilds** — up to 30 members; guild raids weekly.
- **Co-op** — 3-player synchronous raids (Realtime via WebSocket).
- **Marketplace** — soft-currency only; no pay-to-win.
- **Chat** — global, party, guild, whisper; profanity filter + report.

10. Engagement & Retention Hooks

- **Daily login** rewards (7-day streak boost).
- **Weekly quests** + **Seasonal pass** (free + premium tracks; cosmetic only).
- **Mystery Caches** opened with in-game currency only.
- **Level-up surprises** every 5 levels: new mechanic (e.g. lvl 15 unlocks Photo Mode, lvl 25 unlocks Co-op).
- **Mid-realm twists** — narrative reveal at the 50% mark of each realm.
- **End-game** Endless Tower (procedural) + Weekly Rifts.

11. Save & Session UX (critical requirement)

- **Auto-save** triggers: turn end, node enter/exit, menu open, idle 10s.
- **Resume banner** on launch: "Continue Lv 24 — Frostspire Bridge (8 min ago)".
- **Multi-slot manual save** (3 slots) for storyline branching.
- **Seamless server sync** — local IndexedDB cache + delta to server every 30 s.

12. Menu Architecture (high level)

- 1 **Splash** → **Login**
- 2 **Main Menu**: Continue · New Journey · Codex · Multiplayer · Shop · Settings · Quit
- 3 **In-game HUD**: Map · Party · Inventory · Quests · Skills · Pause (auto-save indicator)
- 4 **End-of-mission**: Rewards · Replay · Map · Continue
- 5 **Settings**: Audio · Graphics (Low/Med/High) · Controls · Language · Account · Privacy

13. Art & Audio Direction

- **Art**: 2.5D painterly tiles + vector UI; character art = anime-influenced semi-realistic.

- **Color palette:** realm-coded (verdant green, ember crimson, frost cyan, tide indigo, sky gold, void violet).
- **VFX:** particle-rich aether effects, screen-shake on Resonance.
- **Audio:** orchestral + ethnic instruments; adaptive music intensifies in combat; SFX for every UI tap.
- **Accessibility:** colorblind palettes, dyslexia font, subtitle, reduced motion toggle.

14. Monetization (ethical)

- One-time premium **Founders Pack**.
- Cosmetic-only Battle Pass.
- No loot boxes affecting balance.

15. KPIs / Success Metrics

- D1 retention $\geq 45\%$, D7 $\geq 22\%$, D30 $\geq 10\%$
- Avg session ≥ 18 min
- PvP queue time < 30 s at peak
- 100-level completion rate of top 10% within 90 days

16. Glossary

- **Aether** — life-energy of the world.
 - **Shard** — fragment of the broken Aether core.
 - **Aetherbound** — heroes attuned to a Shard.
 - **Resonance** — combo system trigger.
 - **Drift** — server region.
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Hand-off contract for Step 2

This document is the **canonical scenario**. Step 2 must produce:

- Tech-stack choice that supports: realtime multiplayer, persistent saves, 100 data-driven levels, leaderboards, guilds, marketplace.
- Database that holds: users, characters, levels, runs/saves, inventory, skills, guilds, matches, leaderboards, chat logs, audit.
- Flows for: auth, save/resume, combat turn, level-up, matchmaking, ranking update.